

Source: This meeting in Bombay was attended by 15,000 delegates. Sudhakar Raje (ed.), Onward March: BJP First National Convention Speeches and Resolutions 28–30 December 1980 Bombay, Published by Madhu Deolekar, Publicity Chief BJP (Bombay: Mouj Printing Bureau), p. 50.

Women, the Ram Janmabhoomi Movement and Hindu Nationalism: The Second Phase of the BJP's Growth

If L.K. Advani and his 'rath' had been the 'visual emblems' of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, 'then the voice and words that fixed its message belonged to a woman'.[54] So wrote Tanika Sarkar while studying the role of women in the Ayodhya agitation. This was the second phase of the BJP's growth among women voters. Audio cassettes of fiery speeches by Uma Bharti and Sadhvi Ritambhara and poetry collections like *Shraddha Suman Mala* (Flower Garland of Devotion) by women poets played an important role in the Hindu nationalist upsurge that drove the movement. VHP leaders estimated that about 50,000 female karsevikas were involved in the December 1990–January 1991 Satyagraha in Ayodhya, and about 20,000 of them courted arrest on 4 January 1991.[55] Women were at the vanguard of the temple movement, which thrust a number of Sangh-related women's groups into the limelight: the BJP Mahila Morcha,